KEEP THE GOOD VIBES PAST BEDTIME

Wind-Down Checklist

The anti-meltdown plan. Tape it inside a cabinet door and glance, don't memorize.

Before the last hand (in the final 20 minutes)

- [ ] Close the current game at a natural stopping point - 'last round' means the last round.
- [ ] Start tidying as you play: cards get sorted, cups get ferried to the sink.
- [ ] Announce the timeline: 'Winner gets crowned in 15 minutes, then snacks and goodnight.'
- [ ] Dim the lights one notch. Bodies read dim light as 'winding down.'
- [ ] Crown the champion with the whole table cheering - losers clap too, that's the rule.

If a meltdown is brewing (any age, any size human)

- [ ] Lower the volume before raising it. Whisper - it's surprisingly contagious.
- [ ] Name the feeling, fix nothing yet: 'Losing is disappointing. It's okay to be disappointed.'
- [ ] Offer a small job with both hands: shuffling, snack patrol, holding the score sheet.
- [ ] Take a 'snack break' - food and water fix more arguments than fairness ever will.
- [ ] If someone needs air, walk with them. The game can pause; the people can't.

The calm-down corner (park one before you need it)

A quiet chair with: a glass of water, one soft thing to hold, and the rule that it is not a punishment - it is a pit stop. Grown-ups may use it too, and sometimes should.

After the table empties (tomorrow-you says thanks)

- [ ] Shuffle the decks and return each to its box. Losers make great shufflers.
- [ ] Write down one moment worth keeping - the story, not the score.
- [ ] Put the score sheets and the crowned bracket somewhere visible until next time.

Remember: the pack is about connection, not perfection. If tonight had one laugh, it worked.